HEALTH

The register of trials

A study that never enters a public register is harder to find, and harder to count.

Global · 19 August 2025



A closed notebook, a glass of water and cotton gloves. · AI-generated image

In the medical world, a clinical trial is a plan long before it is a result. Such plans – detailing who is enrolled and what is measured – can be filed in public registries before the first participant is even seen, and the WHO maintains a portal that searches all the registries meeting its standard in one place. [1] The massive registry run by the US National Library of Medicine is the largest of these, but it is just one book, not the entire shelf. [2] Medical journal editors treat trial registration not merely as a courtesy, but as a foundational piece of the scientific record. [3] A trial that is never recorded in a public register, where one cannot walk back to see what initial question was asked, is far more likely to vanish in the dark.

Sources

1. WHO – International Clinical Trials Registry Platform
https://www.who.int/clinical-trials-registry-platform

2. U.S. National Library of Medicine – ClinicalTrials.gov
https://clinicaltrials.gov/

3. ICMJE – Clinical trial registration
https://www.icmje.org/recommendations/browse/publishing-and-editorial-issues/clinical-trial-registration.html